Nice Punch

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Nice Punch

by Xenakis (IceRosesCrown)

Summary

'ADORA! PLEASE! IT DOESN'T ALWAYS HAVE TO BE YOU!" Catra cries before she's shot down. Adora stops as she sees Catra fall to the floor, still reaching for her. She runs back, trying to protect her and right at that moment Catra gets up, pushes her to the ground, and runs in…

When Adora sees Catra take the Failsafe for her, everything loses meaning. She'd rather sacrifice the world than lose Catra. And yet, despite being so visibly volatile, Shadow Weaver couldn't keep her mouth shut, could she?

Notes

As is obvious for my usual readers: this is entirely self-indulgent because I just *love* writing SW being chastised. And, in addition, all I want is for Catra and Adora to get a PROPER apology. (I know, I say this a lot)

So, be my guest, this is as comforting as possible, and might or might not reflect my wish to get such a… genuine apology, despite being objectively terrible. Also might or might not show how much I'd like to reprimand certain people…

Isn't fantasy amazing? You can make *anything* happen, especially the impossible. So I hope you enjoy, and thank SovietOnion for this amazing idea; please read that thread (preferably before this fic) it's great!

See the end of the work for more notes

- Inspired by SovietOnion's twitter thread by SovietOnion, aka, RandomWriting789

Chapter 1

Having just returned from Mystacor, Adora carried between her arms a fainted Catra. Everyone stared in silence as she gently laid her on a make-shift bed next to Spinerella's. She crouched next to her while Melog approached too and curled up at her feet; they both stared at Catra with sorrow, the symbol of the failsafe, *a heart*, glowing right over her chest.

The room remained silent for long minutes, even after everyone else came, wanting to see if Catra woke up. Bow and Glimmer exchanged a worried look and preferred to remain silent, not knowing what could possibly be said now. Everyone quietly watched as Adora held her hand gently, seemingly about to cry.

—You didn't have to do that, you idiot— she whispered with a trembling voice.

Sobbing, she cradled her between her arms, wishing Catra would just wake up, tell her she was only pretending, and they would just laugh at how Adora was crying for her. She wished…

However, not everyone in the room was *considerate enough*, and soon Adora heard behind her —It was her own unwise decision. I already told you getting close to her was a bad choice—. With arms folded and within a meter from them, Shadow Weaver spoke patronizingly, and Adora felt her blood boil. Her arms began trembling around Catra, as she felt a spark of anger suddenly lit inside her. She carefully laid her back on the bed, fearing she might hurt her if she lost control. And it proved to have been for the best when, the next moment, the sorceress added —At least this way her pathetic life will have some mean-

—Agh!—. Adora's cry rang through the whole room; Shadow Weaver was on the floor, and the girl prepared her next punch. —Shut up!

—Adora!

It all happened very fast; everyone reacted a second too late. Melog got between Catra and them, protectively, while Glimmer and Bow rushed to hold Adora's arms. But she's much stronger and now blinded by rage.

—Shut up! Just *shut up*!— she kept yelling, breathing heavily, and struggling to break free from her friends.

As they could barely contain her, Glimmer had to teleport them a few meters away, and Castaspella took the chance to quickly carry Shadow Weaver away. Even when all Adora could see was the broken mask lying on the floor, she still wanted to run and hit her again.

She broke free and charged their way, until she heard —Nice punch—. Her voice was hoarse, but it was unmistakably Catra's. When Adora looked back, the girl wheezed —I coulda… done it better, though.

In a second, her rage waned and she rushed to Catra's side, wanting to hold her again, but hesitating, as if the smallest touch could hurt her. She was panicking but managed to control her voice enough to speak.

—A-are you alright!? Do-do you feel any pain!? Are you…

—Hey… I'm fine— Catra interrupted, giving her voice as much strength as possible.

—Why!? Why the *hell* did you do that!? Do-do you *know* what you did!?— Adora began yelling, unable to hold back her tears anymore. —You could- You could- You…

As her voice trailed off, Catra weakly raised a hand to try and reach for her face, but Adora just cradled her again, holding her more selfishly than she ever had.

—Better me… than you— Catra replied, almost whispering.

—Don't do it, don't deploy it— she pleaded, pressing their foreheads together. —I don't care, just don't…

—Don't be stupid— Catra sighed, interrupting her again. —Someone has to… save the world, right?

Adora could only sob again; she felt immensely relieved to see her awake, but the mere thought of losing her to save everyone else held her heart in a tight grip. She laid Catra down to let her rest and kneeled behind her head, stroking her hair gently. Melog calmed down a bit along with them, and crouched on Catra's left, still noticeably distressed.

Deeper into the shelter, Shadow Weaver sits on a crate, expressionless, while Castaspella *tries* to tend to the cuts on her face left by the broken mask. However, it's a bit difficult to take care of someone's wounds while arguing.

—You couldn't keep your mouth shut this once, no?— the Head Sorceress reproached her, pressing a piece of cloth to her face.

She had barely cleaned a bit of blood when the woman calmly replied —I only spoke the truth.

Castaspella halted; closing her hands she angrily hit her lap as she exclaimed —It was uncalled for!—. She shook her head as she insisted —Not the moment, not necessary…

—And not like I care— Shadow Weaver interrupted her. The sorceress stared at her in disbelief, but she only added —I am *not* a politically correct fool like you.

—*I* am a fool!?— the Head Sorceress cried out, indignant. Then, she scoffed and rebuked —Out of the two of us, who has fresh cuts on her face!?

The woman rolled her eyes and tilt her head back as she deflected —Why do you even care?

Castaspella looked at her with determination as she answered —You just said it, I am *not* like you. Besides—, she reached out to move Shadow Weaver's head back to a more comfortable position to continue cleaning the cuts, then let out —I have a few things to tell you.

—Stop being so polite— the woman groaned. —If you intend to chastise me, just do so.

This time, the sorceress put extra focus on her task, despite her annoyance, while reproaching —It's not just about scolding you! Not *everything* is about you!—. She withdrew the rag to dip it on a bowl with water before continuing, both cleaning the cuts and speaking, as patiently as she could, —This is about Adora, and Catra, and how you couldn't even give them space *now*!—. This time, Shadow Weaver remained silent, so she continued —As I said, it was uncalled for. Catra is hardly conscious, and Adora is a nervous wreck! You're lucky she *only* broke your mask and barely hurt you.

The woman took a deep breath, trying not to move, and nonchalantly uttered —Let me guess: I deserved a worse hit…

—And there you go again, all selfish!

The sorceress withdrew the piece of cloth again and sighed as she thoroughly washed the blood from it. Her complaint, however, left the woman absolutely confused.

—What the heck are you talking about now?

Castaspella took a deep breath and grabbed her by the chin to clean the last cut, while saying —Do you think Adora *enjoyed* punching you!? Couldn't blame her if she did but…— she interrupted herself a moment, and even Shadow Weaver let out a bitter laugh. Noticing the woman really had a terribly twisted way of understanding people's reactions, she sighed resignedly and explained —She's much better than that; she doesn't revel in inflicting pain. If she jumped you like that, you should *know* you overstepped!

This time, Shadow Weaver was the one who withdrew from her. She seemed annoyed, confused, even disgusted, all at the same time; it was difficult for Castaspella to understand what the effect of her words had been.

A moment later, she finally grunted —Whatever do you want me to do about it?

The sorceress put down the rag, mustered all her patience, and suggested —Why don't you start by recognizing what you did wrong?

—I did what *had* to be done— she replied, mildly annoyed but with absolute certainty.

She *really* thinks she's doing "the right thing". Castaspella realized the woman was pretty much under the delusion of being the one who makes "tough but necessary" decisions. Perhaps she needed a push, or a literal kick, in the right direction.

—So you're incapable. Then I'll do it: to begin with, you failed to tell us taking the failsafe could kill Adora…

—I *knew* she'd be fine; better than Catra— Shadow Weaver interrupted. —I did say *Adora* had to act now; it was for her to do.

—Doesn't matter! You are completely missing the point here!— she exclaimed, indignant. Could she be any more stubborn? —You did *not* say a thing about the actual danger! You didn't consider there was *a life* at risk. But let me continue now: Catra took the failsafe instead of Adora and narrowly survived, yet you haven't checked on her *once*!— she reproached, looking right into her deadpan expression. —And if that wasn't enough, you had the *brilliant* idea of saying this gives "meaning" to her "*pathetic life*"! And to Adora, no less! When it's *obvious* she has been worried sick since it happened!— she went on. Shadow Weaver really wanted her to stop, but there was no use in trying, despite how much she hated how *right* she was. Yet she finally reacted when Castaspella exclaimed —How can you be *such* a bitch! What is *wrong* with you!?

—Everything!

—I realize!

Their yelling made the quietness that followed all the more noticeable. They stared at each other in silence for a moment; both angry and stubbornly refusing to let the other win the argument. But after a long minute, Shadow Weaver snarled and looked away resigned.

—And whatever are you planning to do about it?

—Whatever necessary to make sure you apologize to them.

—Why would I!? She *was* reckless!— the woman retorted, indignant. —Shouldn't have done that knowing it wasn't safe!

Castaspella rolled her eyes, and mockingly remarked —Oh really!? That sounds *very* familiar.

The woman seemed genuinely confused, once again, as she asked —What are you talking about now?

—That stupid spell of yours?

—And there you bring it up again— she grumbled, rolling her eyes. —I had my reasons…

—So does Catra, and hers are *way* better than yours!— the sorceress interrupted. —Why can you justify your dangerous spell and not her sacrifice?

—It is not- She just shouldn't have done that!

—How very hypocrite of you!— Castaspella reproached her. —You were warned about trying that spell and still did it, *when you just shouldn't have done that*!

Her condescending tone only angered Shadow Weaver; she retorted —I have already admitted that spell was a mistake!

—And it only took you a couple of decades…

She couldn't take any more of her scolding and asked, with great irritation, —What do you want from me, woman!?

Baffled at her utter ignorance, Castaspella replied, with a similar tone, —I want you to stop being a hypocritical bitch and admit what Catra did was in fact noble! And apologize to Adora for being so insensitive!

She looked away scowling and uttered —Tsk, keep dreaming…

—Lately, I've been hearing about quite a few things you've done to those girls, and guess what?— the Head Sorceress began, challenging. —Your hypocrisy is off the charts! You treat Catra as if you hadn't done the same and worse!— she reminded her. Then, crossing her arms she taunted —I can keep doing this all day, shoving into your face every single one of your "reckless" decisions, so to call them. Eventually, you'll have to admit your *foolishness*.

—Fine! Fine— she immediately replied. Shadow Weaver let out a long resigned sigh and accepted —Finish with these cuts and I'll… attempt to apologize.

With a small triumphant smile, Castaspella cast a quick spell on the water before dipping the rag again and continued tending to her cuts, letting out a satisfied —Good.

—Just…

Her voice sounded weaker, defeated even, and she didn't finish. The sorceress continued carefully applying the magical water to the cuts, accelerating the scarring process, and expecting the woman to continue.

But she didn't, so Castaspella urged her —Say.

—Stay around— she finally requested. —And feel free to interfere if I ruin it— she added with a smirk.

—Sounds a lot like our deal in the forest— she commented, curious.

Shadow Weaver only smirked as she admitted —Same principle.

Adora had lost track of time and had no idea of how long she had been kneeling there. But that wasn't important; right now, nothing else had any relevance to her. The only thing that finally drew her attention away from Catra, was noticing how Melog's head suddenly shoot up, and she immediately regretted looking back.

—Don't you *dare* come any closer!— she warned her with severity.

Shadow Weaver halted and raised both hands, conceding —Alright. I'll stay here.

Castaspella approached too and stopped right next to her as she gently requested —Just… Hear her out, girls. She won't harm you; I won't let her.

—Why should we listen to her?— Adora asked, bewildered.

—I can… barely move…— Catra began, her voice weak but loud enough. —But try to manipulate us… and I'll get up only to scratch you— she threatened.

—Sounds fair— Shadow Weaver replied, mockingly.

—Stop the taunting and apologize now!— Castaspella scolded her, annoyed.

—She? As if…— Catra scoffed.

Looking back at the sorceress with a deadpan expression, the woman was all too ready to give up, but Castaspella pointed at the girls while angrily staring at her. A silent order she preferred not to ignore.

—I… shouldn't have said that— Shadow Weaver finally sighed.

Adora let out a short bitter laugh of disbelief; angry again, she sarcastically replied —You think!?—. Once again, she was trembling. Normally, she'd force herself to be much more respectful, but now she had no reason to do so; she didn't deserve it. —I wonder what made you realize something *so obvious*!

Catra easily noticed from her speech how hurt Adora had to be, and reached out to grab one of her hands and calm her down.

However, the sarcasm flew right over Shadow Weaver's head and the woman gestured at Castaspella, replying —This stubborn excuse of a sorceress.

She looked at her with a disdainful grimace and muttered —I'll punch you myself this time —. Despite hearing that, Shadow Weaver ignored her, so she insisted —Stop digressing!

—Fine!— she reluctantly complied, throwing her arms up. —It was a mistake, omitting how dangerous the failsafe could be. I didn't say it because I *knew* you, Adora, would be fine, as you aren't an Etherian.

Her eyes widened and she looked back at her with consternation as she rebuked —Don't you *think* I would want to know!? Danger never stopped me! But now…—. She interrupted herself as her voice broke, but she went on —Now Catra took it in my stead because we *couldn't* talk this out before going! You took from us the right to decide!

She took from them the right to decide. Somehow, that stroke a chord. Shadow Weaver felt the need to recoil, yet she instinctively forced herself to put up an excuse as she always did.

—I'm aware. But it was the only chance we had.

—Stop with the buts!— Adora immediately reacted. She was still sobbing, holding Catra's hand tighter, and looking at the woman with absolute disappointment. Even pain. —If you are only going to put up excuses I don't want to hear it!

At last, she had the decency to look ashamed. Shadow Weaver sighed and stayed silent, considering once again there was just no point in trying to "apologize", while completely oblivious of the fact she simply didn't know *how* to do so. But Castaspella was *so sure* she had to; the sorceress really believed she could, and the woman had no idea why. Glancing back at her, she noticed that the Head Sorceress was staring with a look that might as well be encouraging, as if reading her thoughts; it was the same insistence from before, so Shadow Weaver finally gave up and put aside her pride.

—I'm sorry.

Adora immediately lifted her head and looked back with a shocked expression, and so did Melog, reflecting Catra's surprise.

—What?— Adora let out, almost like a whisper.

While looking extremely uncomfortable, the woman still continued —I never even thought about… any of that. I am… sorry.

It was impossible for them to believe that was *the* Shadow Weaver they knew. Catra grinned and snickered.

—I think you… hit her too hard— she told Adora, with a mocking yet strained voice. —Do it again.

—Please don't, I'm not a nurse!— Castaspella complained light-heartedly.

—Very funny— the woman uttered sharply. Right after, she sighed again and reminded herself she had to continue. —Listen…— she began, for once pleading instead of demanding. —I have- I've done the same before. Not only ignoring the risks, but also… doing what I was warned not to do; it was… unfair of me to say all of that— she admitted.

—"Unfair"!?— Adora repeated, with both indignation and skepticism. —You said her life had no meaning! You called her "pathetic"!

Catra huffed and accusatorily reminded her —So much for "I see myself in you"… Liar.

—I'm certainly a liar, but that much was true— Shadow Weaver replied, her tone a bit more confident yet not patronizing as usual. She walked around, still far enough from them but moving so she could now see Catra's face. —Like someone just shouted at me…— she began, briefly looking back at Castaspella. —I'm the pathetic one…

Catra made an effort to raise her head and Adora helped her when she noticed. Now resting on her lap, she could see Shadow Weaver's maskless expression. Noticing she was *actually* being honest felt bittersweet.

—So I'm pathetic by… extension?— she scoffed, her voice hoarse. She looked away, pained, and added —Of course, always the… the bad, no?

—Not like there's much good in me to see reflected on you— the woman replied, rolling her eyes.

And there it was again. One step forward, two steps back.

Adora shook her head, looked at Catra for a moment, and then at Shadow Weaver, pointing out —Perhaps if you weren't so… so mean! Why couldn't you see her determination! Her drive! That, in all these years, she hasn't given up!—. Her expression and voice were full of pain, yet she seemed to be holding on to one last bit of hope as she continued —Those are things you have! But you just had to focus on all things *bad*! Considering her disrespectful, flippant, pathetic… All of which you *also* are!—. Adora was getting enraged again; angry tears kept falling, and both Melog and Catra worried. —Why!? Just… Why couldn't you shut up this once!? Why do you always have to voice how much you hate her!?

Melog got up and meowed, approaching Adora to calm her down nuzzling her face, as if washing away the tears. The girls waited for Shadow Weaver to reply; they expected some snarky comeback, or another poor attempt to apologize while simultaneously excusing herself, or even deflecting the blame back at her.

However, the woman just looked away, ashamed, and admitted —I suppose I envy her.

—Great— Catra let out, ironically.

—What was I supposed to do with a young kid who kept your whole attention, was just as good as you, and felt like a more talented version of myself!?— she then burst out, her sight fixed on Adora.

—Encourage her!? Treat her better!? Or at least just like you treated me!?— Adora replied, indignant.

—That was a dream, Adora— Catra sighed, unable to look at Shadow Weaver.

—I don't care if it only happened in a literally broken reality; she could have done so!— she replied angrily. Glaring at the woman once again, she insisted —You *should* have! Why torture her like that!? If you *really* saw yourself in her, why not give her the treatment you would have wanted!?

—Because I never deserved such treatment!

Her frenetic response rang through the room and everyone fell silent; the remaining tension had even Castaspella holding her breath, fearing how this would unfold.

After a long minute, Catra finally let out —So I didn't either?—. Her voice trembled, but she continued, with a bitter chuckle, —Heh… you were ruined… so now you ruin everyone else…

—I suppose I do…— Shadow Weaver admitted, her tone severe yet not like they remembered it. —And I can't exactly undo that. Telling you I'm sorry I said your life is pathetic, and that I should have been honest about the risk of the failsafe *won't* remove it from your heart!

Adora wasn't sure if the anger in her voice was at them, at herself, or because of the whole conversation. Everything felt like a fever dream, but Catra's expression let her know how much this meant for her, despite being so hurtful.

—I don't… I don't care about this thing— she said, as a tear rolled down the side of her face. She turned her face away from her and, with a broken voice, uttered —You won't ever… give me what I want.

Adora caressed her cheek gently, lovingly, and assured her —We need nothing from her. *You* don't need anything from her, Catra; you're worth so much more.

—But I want it…— she sobbed. —It's the only thing I wanted… Yet she only hurt me… hurt us.

Another moment of silence overtook the room. Unbelievably, Shadow Weaver looked down actually ashamed. She couldn't even sigh at this point; knowing there was nothing she could say now, she preferred not to make a sound until she had the right words.

After staring at them for long enough, she hesitatingly let out —I understand… And it would sound fake if I tried to… say it now—. The woman began walking back to the room they had come from, saying —I better leave you two alone—. However, she halted for a moment right next to Castaspella, as if suddenly remembering something, and pushed herself to say one last thing. —That was… brave of you, Catra. Adora was right to get close to you.

Immediately after, she left the room, and the sorceress followed, giving them a pained look.

Catra looked back at Adora, her eyes glistening with more tears, and smiled at her weakly.

—Do you think… she meant it?

—Perhaps— Adora sighed, caressing her hair again while staring at the failsafe glowing over her chest.

Catra chuckled and joked —If you punched some sense into her… then thank you.

But Adora couldn't laugh; remembering how many years had been since Catra first tried to tell her how much Shadow Weaver was hurting her, she could only feel immense guilt.

—I saw it all too late— she sobbed, as some tears fell on Catra's face. As she looked up at Adora with concern while she continued —I should have done this much earlier… before she…

—Shh, it's fine, Adora— Catra interrupted. —Perhaps… it wouldn't have worked earlier… — she tried to comfort her, knowing that "it's not your fault" wouldn't work with her.

—I'm still sorry I didn't stand up for you before, I should have— she insisted. —You were right when you said I never did anything that could put me on her bad side…

—Forget it. It doesn't matter now…— she interrupted her. —I know you really care… And that punch was absolutely worth it.

Her joke worked better this time, and they both smirked as Adora said —I broke her mask… and the cuts…

—You broke more than one mask— Catra pointed out in a low tone. Right after, a thought struck her and she looked to the side, noticing —Wait… Where is it?

Once again, the sorceresses sat on a pair of crates, one in front of the other, both silent. Castaspella sighed and extended the now-repaired mask at Shadow Weaver. The woman took it slowly, noticeably confused.

—Why repair it?

—Take a guess…— the sorceress replied, smirking. Right after, she added —But! If you say "naïve kindness" or "foolishly good" or anything like that…

—You'll punch me too?— Shadow Weaver interrupted, grinning just as smugly, which made Castaspella roll her eyes while holding back a laugh. After a moment of silent reflection, she reckoned —I'd say you're hellbent on proving a point.

—Which would be…

—I have no idea.

She didn't even try; why wasn't Castaspella surprised in the slightest? She rolled her eyes and sighed, resignedly.

—It's obvious you think there is "no point" in apologizing…

—I get it— Shadow Weaver interrupted. —It's just the "right thing to do", not a… means to an end.

The sorceress felt some relief, but part of her doubted she would actually apply that from now on, so she just sighed —Good.

But it wouldn't be *the* Shadow Weaver if she didn't ruin it; with a smirk, she mocked —As moronic as expected from you.

—You!—. The sorceress stood up immediately, ready to charge, but the woman threw her mask at her and ran away. Castaspella fumbled a moment before simply letting it fall to run after Shadow Weaver, crying out —Come back here!

They left behind only the discarded mask on the floor, this time, in one piece.

Epilogue

Chapter Notes

I did a thing

Onion's tweets are literal jewels and, after the last one, I wrote a GREAT scene for *Throw away The Mask* for which I fully owe her. Especially since she even tagged me under it (otherwise I would have missed it), I'm so grateful!!

And because I liked it so much, and think it's only fair, here I'm adding it to this fic, a bit edited at the beginning and end so it fits, but still, I just like it so much (TT^TT), I can't believe I hadn't written it already...

Enough rambling, I hope you like this lil extra!!

—Alright. From the beginning again.

The Head Sorceress had finally caught up to Shadow Weaver just as they reached an open groove, and the both of them had sat down against a slumbering creature, amidst floating shiny specks.

Curiously enough, Shadow Weaver had explicitly requested her help with learning to apologize but, at first, she thought the woman was pranking her. Yet her maskless face let the Castaspella know she was, in fact, quite serious.

—Fine…— she groaned. —To apologize to Catra, I have to…— she began, hesitating and gesturing with her hand while rolling her eyes, as if dismissive of what she was going to say. —Acknowledge that I was… projecting?

—Yes…

—And that she didn’t deserve it…

—Yes…

—Despite behaving like a disrespectful brat.

—Woman!

Castaspella’s annoyed tone had become normal for Shadow Weaver after so many times, and hardly had any impact, especially since she felt the sorceress was being too lenient with her.

—It’s a fact.

—It's uncalled for! You're supposed to be apologizing! Not reproaching *anything*!— she began, indignant, both hands on the ground, supporting her as she leant forward, closer to the dark sorceress. —Besides, I've told you plenty of times: disrespectful or not, we're talking about a kid, a teenager; that so-called "disrespectful" behaviour is normal, to be expected from someone her age, and absolutely *doesn't* justify threats or torture of any kind!

With another dismissive gesture, she looked away as she added —Empty threats to keep her obedient. I would have *never* disposed of her or let Hordak do so. But her behaviour was a sure ticket to Beast island!

—She thought you would kill her! You *explicitly* told her that, if it wasn't for Adora, you would have…

—I know what I said!— Shadow Weaver interrupted, angrily glaring at the sorceress with her fists tightly closed. —I recall every word I told them. Every threat, every lie, and everything I said to convince them they had to be the best or resign to uselessness!

—But why!?

—Because that's how the Horde worked! Only if you're perfect, useful, a necessary weapon, could you be safe from…

—I understand— Castaspella interrupted her, raising a hand to stop her. —But you didn't have to adhere to such thinking. You didn't have to treat them like literal weapons… Did you really think of them like that? I- I don't understand how you could see Etheria as a living creature instead of a weapon but couldn't do the same with Adora! Or Catra! Especially now that she almost died to get the failsafe herself!— she continued, more pained than indignant. —I- Why!? You said it yourself! "Everything the Guild told us was wrong", and so was the Horde! None of you were weapons that had to be perfect… O-only living beings with… all the mortal flaws we are subject to… A-and you said Catra now has some "use"? You can't blame that on the Horde anymore…

The sorceress looked down, her hands pressed over her heart, and a tense silence settled for a long moment.

—Because I was blind? Bitter? How did you call me? Petty? I suppose that applies too— Shadow Weaver admitted, looking away. —Because I didn't care. Even now… I don't know if I care.

Castaspella immediately looked up, sorrowful, and saw her leaning back on the dormant creature again, with a pained expression; she hesitantly put a hand on her shoulder and pointed out —If you didn't care now, you wouldn't have asked for my help nor would you have put so much effort into that apology back there.

—Yet I can't accept the basics— she uttered between her teeth, her eyes closed as she frowned, furious at herself. —I am… *useless* for this.

—No, no— the sorceress immediately replied. —That's the kind of thinking you have to abandon for this. We're *just* starting and… your mindset is *extremely* engraved into your

whole personality now. To break free from it requires a lot of work, so don't be frustrated just now; this is the first step of a long way and you're bound to have plenty of obstacles— she insisted, keeping a gentle tone. —Please don't give up yet. Give yourself more time, and be patient. Could you… trust yourself just a bit more? I promise this is worth it. A-and, perhaps, that way you'll learn to trust Catra too…

Tilting her head away from Castaspella and keeping her sight fixed on the ground, Shadow Weaver asked —Why do *you* trust in me so much? How can you be so… *so stubborn*?

—I… just know there's no point in expecting immediate results. That's *unrealistic.* And I understand this is part of your worldview, so I'm not giving up until you manage to shatter those stupid beliefs that keep bringing you down! Which I *know* you can do, because you've already begun… I-I think the girls deserve your effort, and you mine— she admitted. She then looked away and added —No one else is willing to do so, but this is the only way things can get better.

Suddenly turning back to face her again, Shadow Weaver grabbed the Head Sorceress's arms tightly and exclaimed, with a shaky voice, —It's useless! I am *not* worth the effort! And what's the point if now Catra will die!?

—Yes, you are! And she may not! Trust her!

—No one thinks I'm worth it! And she has doomed herself! I can't do *anything* for her!

—I think you are! For them! I *know* you can at least do this for her!

—Then you're a fool!

—Not more than you for rejecting the only person who believes in you!

—Then let me be a fool!

—I am *not* like you! So I am *not* abandoning you! I won't let this stupid mindset of yours ruin the three of you any further!

Immediately letting go of her, Shadow Weaver pushed herself away from the sorceress a bit, with an unrecognizable expression.

—Why?

—Why not?

—What if they are right?

—No; your three have your kind of mindset in different forms, because of your influence, and it is *wrong*— Castaspella sentenced, moving closer to her with absolute confidence. —I refuse to believe that your twisted mentality can possibly be right. I won't simply stand idle while your bitterness infests your hearts and dooms the three of you.

—You're too naive, too optimistic— she tried to argue.

—Oh no, no. Your view of the world is biased, and by the worst of reasons— she sentenced, leaning towards Shadow Weaver once more. —Right now, you're the fool, the stubborn one. Jus-Just accept the fact that I will *not* give up unless you prove to be the monster you think you are!

Looking away, she placed her hand on the sorceress's shoulder this time and pushed her back slightly.

—Then you better stay away, your stubbornness is contagious…

Castaspella couldn't help but laugh wholeheartedly and barely covered her mouth to hold back a cackle.

—Oh, no. If that's the case, I'll be sticking around until my "optimism", as you called it, passes on to you too— she replied, smiling smugly. As they helped each other stand up, she continued —And you can't do anything about it. You're not getting rid of me.

Right after, the sorceress looped her arm around Shadow Weaver's and pulled from her, walking back to the hideout.

—And here I thought you were finally going to leave me alone…

—Not at all.

—What exactly makes you think I can't simply run away while you sleep?— Shadow Weaver argued.

—Don't make me stay up all night. I swear I *will* if necessary— Castaspella countered. Then, suddenly excited, she added —Oh! I can always ask tonight's guarding shift to keep an eye on you!

—Oh no…

—Oh *yes*!

—Please stop the torture…— she uttered, exaggerating a suffering tone.

—Very funny— the sorceress replied, rolling her eyes as they approached the entrance of the hideout, where everyone was already sharing dinner.

End Notes

I had to end it on the lightest note possible cause I'm soon dropping extreme angst and my readers already hate me enough so...

Yep; hope it gave u a good laugh!

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!